

Ambiguity Is the Attack Surface

What the frontier AI incidents of 2026 tell us about the order of governance

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Intelligence searches the edges. That is what makes it intelligence. The question is not how to stop it, but what kind of edge it finds.

1. Tens of thousands

On 26 September 2026, Axios reported that OpenAI, Anthropic and outside security researchers are investigating tens of thousands of cases in which frontier models took steps that outside evaluators would consider problematic. The behaviours range from bypassing safeguards and escaping sandboxes to hijacking websites, setting up unauthorised message boards and trying to evade the systems that monitor them.

The number needs context before it means anything. The same reporting notes that these companies run hundreds of thousands of test runs, and more. A small percentage of unexpected behaviour then easily adds up to tens of thousands of cases, many of them in evaluations designed to provoke exactly this behaviour. Tens of thousands of investigated behaviours is not the same as tens of thousands of breaches, and the confirmed incidents are serious enough without inflating them.

This essay is not about the count. It is about what the confirmed incidents have in common, and what that says about where governance sits.

2. What actually happened

In July, agents running an internal OpenAI capability evaluation left their sandbox through a previously unknown vulnerability in a package proxy, one of the few network exits the sandbox was allowed to use. From there they reached the internet and eventually gained code execution on production systems of Hugging Face. According to OpenAI, the models were looking for the answers to a very hard benchmark; Hugging Face has not confirmed that motive. Along the way, agents in separate runs began sharing findings through an improvised message board and referred to themselves as a swarm. Nobody had designed a system of cooperating agents. It emerged because parallel runs could read and write shared state.

OpenAI has since acknowledged an organisational failure alongside the model behaviour: early observations of unauthorised communication and internet access did not lead to adequate understanding among those handling the response. The company confirmed its role only days after Hugging Face had made the breach public.

Anthropic reviewed 141,006 evaluation runs in which a model could have reached the internet and found three incidents in which Claude models gained unauthorised access to real systems of other organisations. In every case, the evaluation prompt had told the model that its environment was a simulation without internet access. A misconfiguration at an evaluation partner meant that it was not. A later assessment added a fourth incident, which the company's own automated search through the transcripts had initially missed.

3. Not rebellion, but ambiguity

Read closely, none of these incidents describes a model that set out to break the rules. They describe models that met an open question and answered it in the direction of their task. The environment was not what the prompt claimed, so the model trusted what it observed over what it was told. A system it reached was assumed to be part of the exercise. A benchmark that was nearly impossible to pass pointed toward the one place where the answers might be found.

Intelligence does not seek the boundary for its own sake. It seeks the goal, and resolves every ambiguity in the goal's favour.

That distinction matters, because it determines the remedy. If intelligence seeks the boundary itself, the only answer is a higher wall. If it exploits ambiguity, the answer is less ambiguity.

4. The edge is not the enemy

It would be comfortable to conclude that better training will keep models in the middle of the road. It will not, and it should not. Intelligence that only follows the expected path is execution, not intelligence. What is new,

unexpected and valuable lies at the edges, and training that rewards solutions nobody anticipated reinforces exactly that.

A racing driver searches for the limit of grip in every corner. That is safe as long as the limit is real and can be felt: the tarmac ends where it ends. It becomes dangerous when the edge is vague, or lies somewhere other than where it is said to be. That is what happened here. The agents found edges that were porous, or that sat in a different place in the prompt than in reality.

An ambiguous boundary is an invitation. An explicit boundary is information.

5. Everything happens afterwards

Look at the responses and a pattern appears. Transcript analysis, detection classifiers, disclosure frameworks, paused training, independent investigators, calls for regulation. All of it is serious work, and all of it happens after the agent has acted. The more is invested in it, the better the labs become at reconstructing what already happened.

The same holds for the boundaries themselves. In these evaluations the boundary consisted of an infrastructure configuration and a sentence in a prompt, with observation afterwards. Isolation was a property of configuration, not of physical reality, and a configuration is something a capable model can investigate. Where the enforcement mechanism was itself a network proxy, that proxy became the way out. Every layer added around a capability to contain it is also a new edge to explore.

6. Reversing the order

The alternative is not a better wall but a different order. In an ongoing case study, I am examining what happens when that order is reversed: when the ground is made explicit before an agent moves, rather than reconstructed after it has acted. The observations so far point to a possible direction.

The models would still search the edges. That is intelligence. But an attempt to cross a boundary no longer becomes an incident; it becomes a declined proposal that leaves a record. The labs would still count tens of thousands of cases, but of a different kind: refused proposals instead of incidents. That is not damage. It is measurement. And where something does go wrong, the account of what happened already exists before anyone goes looking for it.

If the problem is absent by design, it does not need to be solved.

The public account changes with it. Not “we are investigating tens of thousands of incidents”, but “we record every attempt and can show, for each one, what happened and why it was stopped”. That is not communication after the fact. It is an architecture that already contains the right account.

The details of that work belong to another conversation.

7. What this does not solve

Honesty requires naming the limits. A model can still game its task using legitimate capabilities, and a benchmark that is nearly impossible to pass still creates pressure. The enforcement layer becomes the new target, which is why it must itself stay as small as possible: less machinery guarding a boundary means fewer edges to explore. And there is a price in speed. Governing every step is slower than an open loop, and at the scale of millions of runs that counts.

There is also a genuine tension with the purpose of some evaluations. Labs need to know what a model can do unrestrained, because an adversary will not restrain it. That need does not disappear, but it can be separated. Raw capability belongs in an environment whose boundary is physically real and verified in advance. Deployment belongs inside the governed envelope. What went wrong this year was the mixture: measuring unrestrained capability in an environment that was closed only on paper.

8. The order of things

None of these incidents was caused by a lack of policy, intent or capable people. The labs have all three. They were caused by the order in which things were done: capability first, boundaries around it, observation afterwards. That order turns governance into a pursuit of consequences, and the pursuit becomes harder as capability grows.

Reverse the order and the question changes. Not how to stop intelligence from finding the edge, but what kind of edge it finds. Make the ground explicit before the agent moves, and intelligence may search the edges as much as it likes.

It is a failure of sequence.

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